

Instructor: ..... Date: .....

Learner: ..... Regional Branch: .....

Program: ..... Center: .....

## CONTENT

- Let's Start! • Let's Explore! • Let's Practice! • Extension Activity • Target Words • Learning Points



### Let's Start!

How do we deal with a difficult customer?



### Learning Outcome

Describe emotions and feelings in present and past situations in spoken or written texts and in work and social contexts.

### Ask your partner:

- Have you ever been a difficult customer? Why? What happened?
- Do you think it is important to stay calm and listen when a customer is upset? Why or why not?

### Can Do Statements

- I can talk about work and dealing with customers.
- I can express that a fairly certain condition will be fulfilled using **when** or **if**.
- I can express willingness and refusal, and make promises and threats.





## Let's Explore!

Vanessa talks about dealing with a difficult customer, and how to **soften\*** the situation.

\* To "soften" means to become less unpleasant or severe.



*Instructions: Read the text aloud.*

All businesses have to deal with upset or angry customers so it's important to know how to deal with this situation. The first step is to address the situation and listen to the customer. If you can get the customer to calm down a little, you will be able to deal with their emotional state. After you do this, you can then use specific problem-solving strategies to address the issue. If you can't diffuse the customer's anger, they will not hear you - they will not be receptive to what you are saying. He or she may become even angrier and react with a threat, "If I don't speak to the manager soon, I will ... " If the customer is agitated, you need to show your willingness to listen carefully to their complaints without interjecting with your own opinions.

If you don't reduce the customer's emotional level, they will not be open to your suggestions. You need to show that you are attuned to their emotional needs. If the customer doesn't think that you are working in their best interest, they will see you as a part of the problem, instead of part of the solution. Remember that customers want to be respected. They want to be acknowledged as an individual, and they want to feel important and valued. As you interact with the customer, you should provide customer-focused responses to show the customer that your intention is to do whatever you can to meet their needs.

Imagine you are a restaurant manager and a server tells you her customer wants to complain. You should go to their table, greet them with a smile and open gestures and body language. Allow the customer to fully explain the problem and vent their anger: "I will not be spoken to like that!" Show that you are listening and can empathize by using statements like, "I see," "I will do everything in my power ... " or "I can understand how you must feel." Try to connect with the customer and let them know that you are on their side. When the problem has been identified and resolved, take the opportunity to apologize for any mistreatment, inconvenience or frustration. At the end of your interaction with the customer, smile and thank them for allowing you to assist. Inquire if there is anything else you can do for them, "Would you like to/Would you like me to... ?"





## Let's Practice!

Vanessa wrote down some suggestions. She made some mistakes. Can you find them?

*Instructions: Use the words from the Word Bank to complete the sentences correctly. Read the complete sentences aloud. Check your pronunciation with your instructor.*

### Word Bank

level / attuned / focused / problem / emotional state

1. If you can get the customer to calm down a little, you will be able to deal with their \_\_\_\_\_.
2. If you don't reduce the customer's emotional \_\_\_\_\_, they will not be open to your suggestions.
3. You need to show that you are \_\_\_\_\_ to their emotional needs.
4. If the customer doesn't think that you are working in their best interest, they will see you as part of the \_\_\_\_\_.
5. As you interact with the customer, you should provide customer-\_\_\_\_\_ responses to show the customer that your intention is to do whatever you can to meet their needs.



## Let's Practice!

Dealing with customers is very important.

*Instructions: Read the text on page 2 again. Select the correct answers to the questions.*

1. According to the writer, the best way to deal with a customer with a problem is:  
a) by interrupting them. b) by contradicting their ideas. c) by dealing with their emotions. d) by taking them to a separate room.
2. You need to consider a person's emotional state, because otherwise ...  
a) they will not listen to you. b) they will not come back. c) they will order something else. d) they will write a complaint letter.
3. You can become part of the problem if:  
a) the customer doesn't listen to you. b) the customer feels you are not attuned to their concerns. c) you become harsh or irritated. d) you quit your job.
4. In dealing with a difficult situation, you should NOT: a) interject. b) ask questions. c) analyze the message. d) call the manager.
5. What the customer really wants is to be ...  
a) carefree. b) happy and content. c) acknowledged and valued. d) trusted.





## Extension Activity

Prepare a role play of an angry customer talking to a salesperson.

*Instructions: Complete the following steps. Fill in the Self-Assessment.*

- Work with a classmate to create a role play between a salesperson and an angry customer. (You can be a salesperson at any store. Use your imagination!)
- Think of reasons why a customer might be angry.
- Think of what a salesperson might do to alleviate this situation.
- Create a dialogue and write it down or take notes so you don't forget what you want to say. Remember to make it sound as natural as possible.
- Practice the dialogue with your classmate.
- Act out the dialogue for your class. Use appropriate body language.
- Discuss which dialogue sounded the most natural or the most polite.

### Self-Assessment

Yes

No

I write down what I want to say.

☐
☐

I use expressions to soften the situation.

☐
☐

I practice the dialogue out aloud with my classmate.

☐
☐

I use body language to help express myself in the role play.

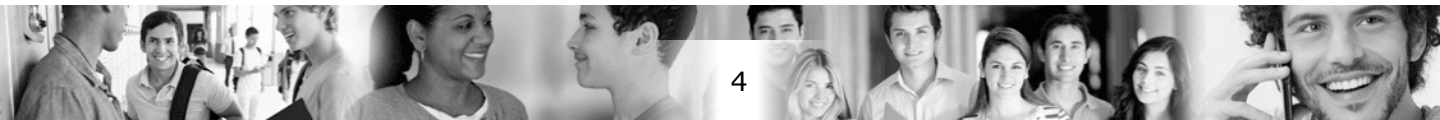
☐
☐

I give feedback on the dialogues and discuss how they sounded.

☐
☐


## Target Words

- emotional state** (noun): the condition relating to your feelings  
e.g. You will be able to deal with their emotional state.
- willingness** (noun): the state of being prepared to do something  
e.g. You need to show your willingness to listen carefully to their complaints.
- to interject** (verb): to interrupt what someone else is saying with a sudden remark  
e.g. Listen carefully to their complaints without interjecting with your own opinions.
- attuned to** (adjective): able to understand  
e.g. You need to show that you are attuned to their emotional needs.
- to acknowledge** (verb): recognized as noticed or heard  
e.g. They want to be acknowledged as an individual.
- interaction** (noun): the activity of talking to other people  
e.g. At the end of your interaction with the customer, smile and thank them for allowing you to assist.





## Learning Points

### The First Conditional: Possibility, Warnings and Threats

You use the First Conditional with if-clauses to exchange opinions about possible future outcomes.

You use the First Conditional to say it's possible that you will or will not do something. In that condition, something else may, may not, will or will not happen. The outcome is not in the present, but in the future.

**Example:** *If you focus more on our customers, they'll leave a larger tip.*

You also use the First Conditional to suggest a warning or a threat.

**Example:** *If you don't focus on our customers, we'll keep on getting bad reviews.*

Structure:

*If + Present Simple ... will + verb ...*

#### Examples:

- *If you can get the customer to calm down a little, you will be able to deal with their emotional state.*
- *If you can't diffuse the customer's anger, they will not hear you.*
- *If the customer doesn't think that you are working in their best interest, they will see you as part of the problem.*





## Learning Points

### Willingness, Refusal, Promises and Threats

You use *will* or *won't* to express willingness, refusal, promise and threat in situations in the present or in the future.

There are different ways to use *will* or *won't*. In the following uses, we don't necessarily talk about a future action or an event that will take place at a point in time in the future. Instead, *will* or *won't* are used to express willingness, refusal, promise or threat related to an action which could be in the present or in the future.

Look at the following examples:

- Willingness:

*Will you clean the restaurant kitchen with me, please?*

- Refusal:

*I will not tolerate this behavior in the kitchen any longer.*

*The computer won't start.*

- Promise:

*I'll do everything I can to satisfy our customers.*

- Threat:

*If you refuse to help me, I'll have to take extreme measures.*

### Examples:

- *If I don't speak to the manager soon, I will never come back here again!*
- *I will not be spoken to like that!*
- *I will do everything in my power to help you.*
- *Would you like to speak to the manager now?*
- *Will you be able to come in tomorrow?*

